

Basic Guide to Filing Personal Income Taxes

Filing your taxes can be straightforward if you organize your financial documents ahead of time. This guide outlines key forms and deadlines.

Understanding W-2 and 1099 Forms

A **W-2 form** is provided by employers to report annual wages earned and taxes withheld. A **1099 form** is used for independent contractors, freelancers, or interest/dividend income.

Standard Deductions vs Itemized Deductions

The standard deduction reduces your taxable income by a fixed amount based on your filing status. Alternatively, you can choose to itemize deductions if your eligible expenses (like mortgage interest, medical expenses, and charitable contributions) exceed the standard deduction threshold.

Important Tax Deadlines

The federal income tax filing deadline in the United States is typically April 15th of each year. If you need more time, you can file Form 4868 to request an automatic 6-month extension to file, moving your filing deadline to October 15th.